See Through

By Andrea Gibson

(Pg 65-68)

We're on our way back to school from gymnastics class.

The kids are singing John Lennon's ***Imagine***

at the back of the bus,

(sing) ***** *. . . Imagine no possessions . . . I wonder if you can . . . No need for greed or hunger . . . A brotherhood of man . . . Imagine all the people . . . Sharing all the world."*

Jesse stops herself mid-verse,

stretches her arm across the aisle like a sunbeam,

tugs at the hem of my shirt and asks,

"What does hatred mean?"

INTRODUCTION

(Big breath and hold it; let it out in a gush) A bus full of white children in Boulder, Colorado. White privilege as far as the eye can see. Yes, I said it – "white privilege" – but what does that even mean? Spoiled rich kids? No.

White privilege *describes the advantages that white people have based on their skin color. You could be poor as "dirt" (as my daddy used to say) but if you happen to be born white, your skin color has given you a built-in leg up over people of color.*

It's difficult for adults to understand the concept, so how do you explain "white privilege" to a group of children? Andrea Gibson ponders this dilemma in her poem See Through

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Jesse's five years old.

Anything I say, she's going to believe.

But I realize I don't know the answers.

I don't know what hatred means.

I could guess and say it's the opposite of love.

I could guess and say,

"Jesse, hatred is wanting nothing but white faces

on our private-school bus."

But Jesse isn't white yet.

Go ahead and ask her.

"What color are you, Jesse?"

"Well, it looks like I'm pink."

Shane thinks he's orange.

Skylar says she's tan.

Rhett says he's see-through.

“See, you can see how my veins are blue
but they're red when i bleed.”

And I wish there was no such thing as springtime.
‘Cause I don't trust the machines
that will one day be planting seeds in these gardens
teaching them that some people are flowers
some people are weeds,
rip the weeds by their roots
ignore their screams
tilt your own face to the sun
take what you want,
you are the chosen ones.

I wanna tell Jesse that Sitting Bull was wrong
when he said that white people are liars and thieves.

I wanna tell her we didn't come like a time bomb,
gunpowder on our breath,
teeth built like bullets,
that this land didn't weep when our feet
first mercilessly hit the ground.
I don't wanna say we drowned and maimed the children,
sliced long strips of their skin for bridal reigns.

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I don't wanna say the moon was slain,
the constellations dispersed like shrapnel.
Jesse, mothers killed their babies, then killed themselves
when they saw our faces on the horizon
and all that we left was a trail of tears.

But if I have to say that
I wanna say our boats stopped there.
I wanna say the waves never saw the sails of slave ships,
never heard the sound of chain links,
but Jesse, think slaughterhouse.
Think people branded, suffocating, foaming at the mouth.
Can you imagine what kind of pain you would have to
endure
to throw yourself overboard 1200 miles out to sea?
Lungs gratefully exchanging breath for saltwater,
gratefully trading life for death.

Can you imagine being chained to your dead daughter?
How many days would it take you to stop
searching her hands for lifelines?
To stop searching her fingertips for memories of sunshine?
To stop searching her wrists for a pulse,

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for just some sign of time turning backwards
to when you just knew
people would never do things like this?

And jesse this
is not just a picture of our history,
not just a picture of our past.
We've been hundreds of years
measuring the size of their hearts
by the size of our fists,
erecting our bliss on the broken backs of dark skin.
The present is far from gift wrapped.

Ask mothers in the Bronx
chasing rats out of their babies' cribs.
Ask the fathers of the kids
whose lives we exchange for cheap gas.
Ask our prisons why jail bars always come in black.
Ask the woman in Thailand whose cancer build our laptops.
Ask the Mexican man working in a field fertilized by nerve gas.
Ask his daughter when she's born without fingers
or hands to pray with.

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(ask me how long I could keep going with this list)
God might be watching,
but we are not.

You are white, Jesse
There are bodies dangling
from the limbs of your family tree.
Our people pull people from their soil like weeds.
Breathe in our story.
Force yourself to hold it in your lungs
'til you can hear our hymns sung beneath white sheets.
Feel yourself fire as they shout.
Do not look away as bullet enters heartbeat.
Now breathe out.
This is where we come from.
This is still where we are.
Now, where will we go from here?

I don't believe we're hateful.
I think we're just asleep.
But when we wake we can't call up the dead and say,
"Sorry, we were looking the other way."

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There are names and faces behind our apathy,

eulogies beneath our choices.

There are voices deep as roots

thundering unquestionable truth

through the white noise that pacifies our ears.

Don't tell me we can't hear.

Don't tell me we don't hear.

When the moon is slain,

when the constellations disperse like shrapnel,

don't you think it's time

something changed?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

Music and Lyrics to Imagine by John Lennon
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dT4hLudO-is

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